CLIMATE & ENVIRONMENT

The Climate Struggle: What Makes It Hard?

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Even though there are multiple paths leading to the same goal, the chosen path must not be so strict as to discourage participation, nor so loose as to leave insufficient effort unpunished. The Kyoto Protocol and the Paris Agreement were ratified by numerous states to slow down global warming by reducing greenhouse gas emissions. While the targets set in the Kyoto Protocol were intended to be secured through sanctions, the states ratifying the Paris Agreement set their targets freely, without the fear of penalties.

Under the Kyoto Protocol, only developed countries committed to reducing greenhouse gas emissions. While the US, one of the countries with high greenhouse gas emissions, did not ratify this protocol, nations classified as developing countries, such as China and India, were exempted from binding emission reduction targets. Among the ratifying nations, Canada became the first state to withdraw from the protocol. Because it withdrew before completing the first period in which emissions would be measured, it did not face any sanctions.

Although all the other states that set targets achieved their emission reduction goals on paper, some countries reached these targets by purchasing carbon credits. Since certain states responsible for high levels of emissions had no obligation to set targets due to their developing status, the rate of emission growth could not be reduced to the desired extent. Under this protocol, the uneven distribution of emission reduction responsibilities and its high cost, combined with the prospect of sanctions, deterred states. This was because a state that failed to reach its goal through its own efforts would either have to buy carbon credits or be penalized with even more of what it had already failed to achieve by being held responsible for an increased carbon reduction target in the next period.

In the Paris Agreement, on the other hand, as the price of keeping all parties in the game, a method aimed at encouraging rather than punishing was adopted from the outset. What, then, would motivate states to take action in the absence of a threat of sanctions? One might assume that states' efforts in this struggle would increase in proportion to the costs of potential disasters likely to strike them as a result of climate change. However, a fair assessment of the general trajectory is only possible by considering that not all countries fighting emissions are developed nations, and that states grappling with more urgent needs are also part of this effort. Indeed, it was acknowledged from the very beginning in the Paris Agreement that it would take longer for emissions in developing countries to stop rising and begin to decline.

In essence, whatever path is chosen, states will represent distinct challenges due to their differing characteristics. The largest sources of greenhouse gas emissions, which have been rising since the Industrial Revolution, are basic human needs such as energy production, industry, transportation, buildings, agriculture, and land use. Knowing the sources actually reveals the primary pathways for reducing emissions. However, it does not guarantee that every step along the way will be taken with the same ease.

The more widespread an emission source is, the harder the fight against that source becomes. For example, the United Kingdom successfully passed its tough test with coal by closing its last coal-fired power plant. Yet, even though the number of coal-fired power plants is quite small compared to vehicles in domestic transport and buildings in need of heating, this test lasted for decades. The fact that the struggle will now concentrate on transportation and heating has raised the difficulty level of the emissions test by several notches at once.

The reason for the difficulty may also be the scale of the targets set. Australia, one of the states that set an ambitious emission reduction target, has made progress with renewable energy in electricity; nevertheless, it needs comprehensive policies and plans proportional to the magnitude of its goals. Such plans and policies, however, require both a fast-functioning procedure and public support for the changes they will bring in order to be implemented in time.

Being vulnerable to the dangers posed by the greenhouse gas-induced climate crisis will not automatically bring the money and capacity needed for the fight. The climate crisis does not need a visa to cross borders, and the crisis-level consequences of individual countries ultimately cause global impacts. Chile is one of the countries standing right in the middle of this dilemma. When the predicted flood risk along its central coasts is added to the threat of high temperatures in its northern regions, waging a greater struggle becomes imperative, and Chile does have plans and legal regulations in this regard. However, while fighting the climate crisis, factors that are allies of the crisis—such as a lack of capacity and financing—are also part of the struggle. Let alone developing countries, even strong economies feel that every financial step becomes more exhausting as they change their habits.

On the other hand, not every statistical decline may be an expression of success in the struggle. Some statistics hide carbon leakage or similar situations behind them. In this regard, Japan cited the decarbonization of electricity generation and the decline of domestic production in the manufacturing sector as the main reasons for the decrease in its emissions. However, a decline in domestic manufacturing does not show that the consumption of products whose manufacture causes emissions has also decreased. Therefore, in such declines, instead of disappearing, the emission merely relocates and continues to exist as a global burden.

Sometimes states, much like individuals, may appear willing and then step back along the way. If commitments are secured through sanctions, loopholes in agreements must be closed to prevent withdrawal from being a party without paying a price, as happened in the Kyoto Protocol. If they are not subject to sanctions, it would arguably be more appropriate to base the main plan on the past attitudes of states. Indeed, the fact that Canada—the first country to abandon the Kyoto Protocol—removed the consumer carbon pricing mandate through regulations that halted the implementation of the fuel charge illustrates the situation more clearly.

It is obvious that the cost for states to fight emissions and the climate crisis is high. Still, they may all appear to have stayed in the game. Well then, considering that governments change and economic conditions put pressure on them, will the non-sanctioned target-setting procedure in the Paris Agreement cause this pact to turn into group therapy? Although we do not know the answer to this for now, the world will continue to warm unless large-scale carbon emission cuts are made. As storms intensify, we may see a considerable increase in floods and the number of extinct species. Perhaps a few decades from now, when scientists look back at the genetic maps of natural disasters, they will realize that the future disasters caused by the global climate crisis descend from the very same lineage as the ones we have been experiencing for some time.

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